Master's Thesis

Research Proposal

AI Self-Efficacy and AI Adoption Intention

Trust in AI and Perceived Job Threat as Parallel Mediators in Austrian Organizations

Submitted by
SCHUCHNIGG Elias

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Supervisor	Dr.Mag.Mag.rer.soc.oec Stefan Bauer, Bakk.

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Vienna, 28.05.2026	Elias Schuchnigg
Place, date	Author's name

Table of Contents

Table of figures II

List of Tables III

List of abbreviations IV

1 Initial Situation, Problem Statement and Research Gap 1

2 Objective and Research Question 5

2.1 Research Question 5

2.2 Hypotheses 6

3 Methodology 8

3.1 Research Design and Data Collection 8

3.2 Construct Operationalization 8

3.3 Sampling 10

3.4 Data Analysis 10

3.5 Quality Criteria and Ethical Considerations 11

4 Thesis Structure 12

5 Time Management 15

Bibliography 17

List of tools used 21

Table of figures

Figure 1: Proposed Research Model 7

List of Tables

Table 1: Thesis Structure 14

Table 2: Time Schedule.....16

List of abbreviations

AI	Artificial Intelligence
AIM AT 2030	Artificial Intelligence Mission Austria 2030
EU	European Union
SEM	Structural Equation Modeling
PLS-SEM	Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling
TAM	Technology Acceptance Model
UTAUT	Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology
VIF	Variance Inflation Factor

1 Initial Situation, Problem Statement and Research Gap

In Austria, the share of organizations using artificial intelligence (AI) nearly doubled within a single year, rising from 11% in 2023 to 20% in 2024 (Statistik Austria, 2024, p. 1). That figure says something about organizations. However, this figure says less about the employees working in these organizations. Organizational AI adoption does not automatically mean that employees actively use AI in their daily work. This gap is central to the study.

Research on technology acceptance has examined the use of digital systems for several decades. The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) explains technology use mainly through perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use (Davis, 1989, p. 320). The Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT) extends this view by including social influence and facilitating conditions as further factors shaping technology use (Venkatesh, Morris, Davis & Davis, 2003, pp. 425–427). These models provide an important basis for understanding why employees accept or reject new technologies.

AI systems are a different kind of technology, though. A spreadsheet does what you tell it. An AI system learns, adapts and sometimes produces outputs that are genuinely difficult to interpret, and in many workplaces those outputs influence decisions about performance, roles, or hiring. Venkatesh (2021, p. 641) argues that AI adoption therefore requires attention to individual and contextual factors that earlier models were not designed to capture. A systematic review of AI acceptance research confirms that trust in AI and perceived risk emerge as predictors of adoption intention that go beyond what TAM and UTAUT were built to explain (Kelly, Kaye & Oviedo-Trespalacios, 2023, pp. 1–2).

Trust matters here precisely because understanding often does not. When an employee cannot check how an AI reached a conclusion, following that output rests on confidence in the system rather than verification of its logic. Glikson and Woolley (2020, pp. 627–628) define trust in AI as employees' willingness to rely on AI-generated outputs based on their perceptions of reliability and competence. If employees do not trust the system, they may avoid using it or rely less on its recommendations, even when it could support their work (Hoff & Bashir, 2015, pp. 407–412). Choung, David and Ross (2022, p. 2) show that trust in AI can predict acceptance beyond standard TAM variables. Li, Wu, Huang and Luan (2024, pp. 1–3) further show that trust formation also depends on user-level characteristics. The same AI system may therefore lead to different trust responses among different employees.

AI adoption can also create concerns among employees. One relevant concern is perceived job threat, which refers to the subjective perception that one's job or professional role is at risk (Sverke, Hellgren & Näswall, 2002, pp. 243–250). In the context of AI, this threat is closely

linked to the possibility that AI systems may take over tasks currently performed by employees. Kim and Kim (2024, p. 1) explain that AI can create concerns because it may be able to perform work activities for which employees are currently responsible. Perceived job threat is therefore relevant for understanding whether employees are willing to use AI at work or whether they respond to it with hesitation.

Together, trust and perceived job threat represent two different reactions to AI in the workplace. Trust may increase employees' willingness to engage with AI systems. Perceived job threat, in contrast, may reduce it. Duong et al. (2025, p. 1) describe these reactions as approach-oriented and avoidance-oriented behavioral responses. However, it remains insufficiently clear where these perceptions originate. Employees may work with the same AI system in a similar organizational context but still develop different attitudes toward it. This suggests that individual factors may help explain why employees trust AI or perceive it as threatening (Li et al., 2024, pp. 1–3). From the perspective of social cognitive theory, self-efficacy beliefs are especially relevant because they shape how individuals interpret situations and how they act within them (Bandura, 1997, p. 3). Therefore, this study focuses on AI self-efficacy as one possible explanatory factor.

AI self-efficacy describes how confident individuals feel in their ability to use AI technologies effectively (Wang & Chuang, 2024, p. 4787; Bandura, 1997, p. 3). It goes beyond AI knowledge, as a person may know about AI but still feel unsure about using it. This confidence is relevant because individuals with higher self-efficacy are more likely to engage with new technologies, while those with lower self-efficacy may avoid them (Compeau & Higgins, 1995, p. 191).

In practice, AI self-efficacy may develop through experience. Employees who achieve useful results with AI tools may become more confident in their ability to use these systems. Employees who repeatedly receive poor or unusable results may become less confident. This can happen, for example, when unclear instructions lead to outputs that do not support the work task. Montag, Kraus, Baumann and Rozgonjuk (2023, p. 1) support this view by showing that technology self-efficacy is positively related to trust in AI and negatively related to fear of AI. Their findings suggest that confidence in using technology can influence how individuals evaluate AI systems.

Further evidence indicates that self-efficacy may also affect how threatening AI feels to employees. Kim and Kim (2024, p. 1) show that self-efficacy in AI learning can reduce the negative psychological effects of AI-induced job insecurity. This means that employees with higher self-efficacy may experience AI as less threatening, even when they are exposed to the same technology. Wang and Chuang (2024, pp. 4787–4789) also argue that AI self-efficacy should

be measured as a specific construct and not only through general computer self-efficacy scales. Taken together, these findings suggest that AI self-efficacy shapes how employees interpret the same technology, and through that interpretation, how willing they are to adopt it.

Austria provides a relevant context for examining these relationships. In 2024, only 27% of Austrians rated their AI knowledge as high, while 28% had used generative AI tools in the previous three months (Statistik Austria, 2025, pp. 11, 23). This indicates that AI is becoming more visible, but that actual experience with AI remains limited among many people. Austria also remains below its Digital Decade target for basic digital skills. The current level is 64.7%, while the target is 80% (Federal Chancellery Republic of Austria, 2025, pp. 12–13). This is relevant because digital skills differ across social groups and may influence how prepared employees feel when working with AI. Zavodna, Überwimmer and Frankus (2024, pp. 331–332) also identify limited knowledge and lack of trust as barriers to AI implementation in Austrian and Czech companies. In addition, Austria's national AI strategy, the Artificial Intelligence Mission Austria 2030 (AIM AT 2030), treats the relationship between AI and the workforce as an important policy issue (OECD, 2025, p. 1). Therefore, Austria is a suitable setting for studying the gap between organizational AI deployment and employees' readiness to use AI.

Although more research on AI adoption is emerging, the role of AI self-efficacy as an upstream variable remains underexplored. Existing studies often examine AI self-efficacy either as a direct predictor of adoption alongside standard TAM variables (Lan, Liu, Chen & Xia, 2026, p. 1) or as a moderator of job insecurity effects (Kim & Kim, 2024, p. 1; Sha & Chai, 2025, p. 1). However, less is known about whether AI self-efficacy influences both trust and perceived job threat within one integrated model, and whether these two perceptions explain its relationship with adoption intention. This is the research gap addressed in this study.

The central academic problem is therefore that AI self-efficacy is rarely examined as an explanatory starting point for both trust in AI and perceived job threat within one model. Social cognitive theory suggests that self-efficacy beliefs influence how individuals interpret situations and how they act within them (Bandura, 1997, p. 3). Applied to AI in the workplace, this means that employees' confidence in their ability to use AI may influence whether they perceive AI systems as reliable and competent or as threatening to their professional role. This study therefore examines trust in AI and perceived job threat as parallel mechanisms through which AI self-efficacy affects behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies.

Testing the model in Austrian organizations adds further relevance. Austria is shaped by the European Union (EU) Digital Decade, a national AI strategy focused on workforce readiness, and a gap between organizational AI deployment and individual AI readiness. This makes Austria a suitable context for examining how employees develop trust, perceive job threat and

form intentions to use AI (Statistik Austria, 2024, p. 1; Statistik Austria, 2025, pp. 11, 23; Federal Chancellery Republic of Austria, 2025, pp. 12–13; OECD, 2025, p. 1).

2 Objective and Research Question

Building on the research gap identified in Section 1, this study aims to examine how AI self-efficacy influences employees' psychological orientation toward AI technologies and whether this orientation explains their willingness to adopt AI tools in the workplace. Existing research suggests that self-efficacy may represent an important antecedent of both trust and perceived job threat (Montag et al., 2023, p. 1; Kim & Kim, 2024, p. 1). Employees with higher AI self-efficacy may be more likely to perceive AI technologies as reliable and competent, whereas employees with lower AI self-efficacy may be more likely to experience AI as threatening. Against this background, trust and perceived job threat are expected to transmit the effects of AI self-efficacy on behavioral intention to adopt AI. Therefore, the primary empirical objective of this study is to test this parallel mediation model.

The study also has a contextual objective. By focusing on Austrian organizations, this thesis examines a setting in which the implementation of AI technologies has increased, while employees' individual AI-related competence may not have developed at the same pace (Statistik Austria, 2024, p. 1; Statistik Austria, 2025, pp. 11, 23; Federal Chancellery Republic of Austria, 2025, pp. 12–13). This discrepancy may create relevant differences in employees' levels of AI self-efficacy, making Austria a suitable context for testing the proposed model. From a practical perspective, the findings may provide insights for organizations that invest in AI technologies but experience lower levels of employee adoption than expected.

The theoretical foundation of the model is based on social cognitive theory. According to Bandura (1997, p. 3), self-efficacy beliefs influence behavior partly by shaping how individuals evaluate the situations they encounter. Applied to the context of AI, employees' confidence in their ability to use AI tools effectively may influence whether they perceive the same technology as reliable or as threatening. Research suggests that technology self-efficacy predicts trust in automated systems and that trust mediates the relationship with acceptance (Montag et al., 2023, p. 1). Kim and Kim (2024, p. 1) provide evidence for the role of perceived threat by showing that self-efficacy in AI learning moderates the psychological effects of AI-induced job insecurity. However, these studies do not examine self-efficacy as a shared antecedent of both trust and perceived job threat within one integrated model. This represents the contribution of the present study.

2.1 Research Question

How does AI self-efficacy influence employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies in Austrian organizations, and to what extent is this relationship mediated by trust in AI and perceived job threat?

Sub-Questions

1. To what extent does AI self-efficacy positively influence employees' trust in AI in Austrian organizations?
2. To what extent does AI self-efficacy negatively influence employees' perceived job threat in Austrian organizations?
3. To what extent does trust in AI positively influence employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies in Austrian organizations?
4. To what extent does perceived job threat negatively influence employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies in Austrian organizations?
5. Do trust in AI and perceived job threat mediate the relationship between AI self-efficacy and employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies?

2.2 Hypotheses

Since the thesis will follow a quantitative approach, the following hypotheses will be tested:

H1: AI self-efficacy has a significant positive effect on employees' trust in AI.

H2: AI self-efficacy has a significant negative effect on employees' perceived job threat.

H3: Trust in AI has a significant positive effect on employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies in Austrian organizations.

H4: Perceived job threat has a significant negative effect on employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies in Austrian organizations.

H5: Trust in AI and perceived job threat jointly mediate the positive relationship between AI self-efficacy and employees' behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies (parallel mediation model).

The hypotheses are based on research on self-efficacy, trust, perceived threat and AI adoption. H1 assumes that AI self-efficacy increases trust in AI, as technology self-efficacy has been shown to predict trust in AI and reduce negative perceptions of AI systems (Montag et al., 2023, p. 1; Lan et al., 2026, p. 1). H2 assumes that AI self-efficacy reduces perceived job threat, since employees with higher self-efficacy may experience AI-induced job insecurity as less psychologically harmful (Kim & Kim, 2024, p. 1).

H3 and H4 focus on adoption intention. Trust in AI is expected to increase employees' willingness to adopt AI, while perceived job threat is expected to reduce it (Glikson & Woolley, 2020,

pp. 627–628; Choung et al., 2022, p. 2; Kelly et al., 2023, pp. 1–2; Sverke et al., 2002, pp. 243–250; Duong et al., 2025, p. 1). H5 brings these relationships together in a parallel mediation model, where AI self-efficacy affects adoption intention partly through trust and perceived job threat. This indirect effect will be tested using bootstrapping-based mediation analysis. The study focuses on intention to adopt AI rather than actual use, as TAM and UTAUT treat intention as a close predictor of use (Davis, 1989, p. 320; Venkatesh et al., 2003, p. 427).

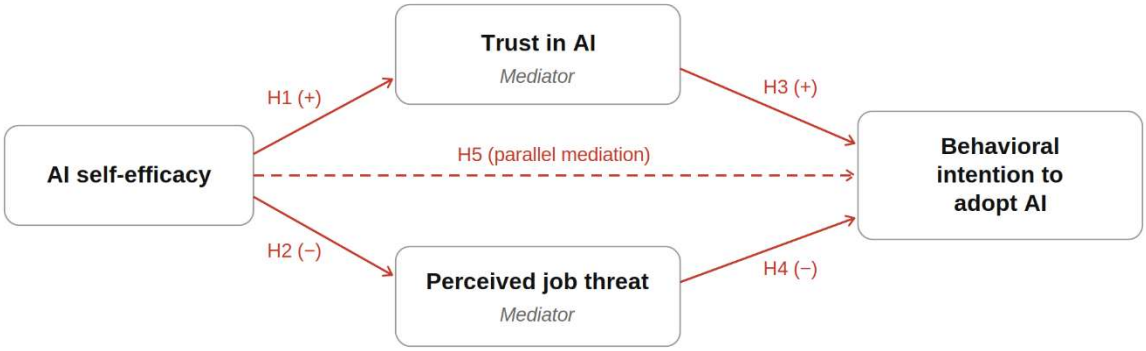


Figure 1: Proposed Research Model

3 Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Data Collection

To answer the research question and test the proposed hypotheses, this study applies a quantitative research design. The thesis examines the relationships between AI self-efficacy, trust in AI, perceived job threat and behavioral intention to adopt AI in the workplace. These relationships are derived from existing theory and specified before data collection. A quantitative approach is therefore suitable, as it allows the proposed model to be tested against empirical data. It also allows the strength and direction of the relationships between the constructs to be examined systematically. The study follows a positivist research orientation, as the selected constructs are treated as measurable phenomena. This means that the research assumes that the relationships between the constructs can be assessed through standardized measurement.

A qualitative design would provide valuable insights into employees' personal experiences with AI. However, it would not be suitable for testing the proposed parallel mediation model. Since the study examines predefined relationships between latent psychological constructs, primary data will be collected through a standardized online questionnaire. This allows the constructs to be measured within the respondents' current organizational context. Primary data are necessary because employees' perceptions of AI may depend on their own workplace situation and cannot be derived from existing datasets. As the constructs cannot be observed directly, validated multi-item scales will be used (Hair, Risher, Sarstedt & Ringle, 2019, pp. 2–4).

3.2 Construct Operationalization

Measuring psychological constructs such as trust or self-efficacy involves a certain degree of approximation. Therefore, the aim is to select instruments that are closely aligned with the theoretical definitions used in this study and that can be adapted to the specific context of AI use in Austrian organizations. All constructs are operationalized as reflective latent variables and measured with multi-item scales, as recommended for latent constructs in PLS-SEM research (Hair et al., 2019, pp. 2–4). The items are measured on a seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = "strongly disagree" to 7 = "strongly agree."

AI self-efficacy is operationalized using a four-item scale from Kim and Kim (2024, p. 7). This scale is based on Bandura's (1997, p. 3) social cognitive theory and was developed specifically for the context of AI use at work. It is preferred over general technology self-efficacy instruments because Wang and Chuang (2024, pp. 4787–4789) show that AI self-efficacy is domain-

specific and cannot be adequately captured by general computer self-efficacy scales (Compeau & Higgins, 1995, p. 191). Example items include: “I am confident in my ability to learn AI technology appropriately in my work” and “I am able to learn AI technology to perform my job well, even when the situation is challenging” (Kim & Kim, 2024, p. 8).

Trust in AI is measured with the functionality-related trust scale by Choung et al. (2022, p. 2). The scale captures whether employees see AI systems as reliable, competent and consistent. This fits the understanding of trust as depending on how well a system appears to work in an organizational setting (Glikson & Woolley, 2020, pp. 627–628). Since transparency can also influence trust, this aspect is considered in the wording of the items (Wanner, Herm, Heinrich & Janiesch, 2022, p. 2080). Adapted example items include: “I believe the AI tools I use at work produce reliable results” and “The AI-based systems I work with behave consistently and predictably” (Choung et al., 2022, p. 14).

Perceived job threat is measured with the five-item AI-induced job insecurity scale by Kim and Kim (2024, p. 7). The scale captures concerns about job replacement, outdated skills and changes to one’s professional role. It is suitable for this study because job threat is examined specifically in relation to AI adoption. The construct builds on job insecurity research, where job insecurity refers to the subjective perception that one’s job may be at risk (Sverke et al., 2002, pp. 243–250). Adapted example items include: “The introduction of AI technologies makes my job feel insecure” and “I am concerned that AI could replace tasks that are central to my professional role” (Kim & Kim, 2024, p. 7).

Behavioral intention to adopt AI is measured through employees’ intention to use AI-based tools in their work. The items are adapted from Venkatesh et al. (2003, pp. 425–427) and adjusted to the respondent’s current work context. Adapted example items include: “I intend to use AI-based tools in my work in the future” and “I plan to integrate AI tools into my regular work processes” (Venkatesh et al., 2003, p. 460).

Since the target population works in Austria, the questionnaire will be administered in German. The English items will therefore be translated into German and reviewed to preserve their original meaning. To check the accuracy of the translation, the German items will be compared with the original English wording before the final questionnaire is assembled. The items will also be checked for their fit with AI use in Austrian organizations.

Control variables are used to account for demographic, professional and AI-related differences between respondents. They include age, gender, educational level, occupational field, industry, years of work experience and current frequency of AI use. These characteristics may influence technology adoption intentions (Venkatesh et al., 2003, pp. 427–428).

3.3 Sampling

The model tested in this study requires respondents who regularly use AI in their work. General awareness of AI is not sufficient, as the study examines work-related perceptions such as self-efficacy and trust. Therefore, the target group consists of employees working in Austrian organizations who use AI-based tools as part of their job.

This criterion is checked through a filter question at the beginning of the questionnaire. Respondents are asked whether they regularly use AI-based tools in their current job, such as ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, AI-supported decision tools, automated workflows or AI-supported communication systems. Respondents who answer “No” are excluded from the survey.

A non-probability sampling strategy is used. The sample will be collected through convenience sampling and targeted outreach. Participants will be approached through LinkedIn and direct contacts within organizations. Employees from different sectors, such as finance, professional services, manufacturing and healthcare, will be included to capture different levels of AI use and perceptions of AI.

The questionnaire will take about ten to twelve minutes to complete and will be available for four weeks. The study aims to collect 150 to 200 valid responses. This target is considered appropriate for the planned Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM), as sample size requirements in PLS-SEM depend on model complexity, expected effect sizes and statistical power rather than on a fixed universal threshold (Hair et al., 2019, pp. 4–8; Kock & Hadaya, 2018, pp. 227–261). The larger sample is intended to make the results more reliable, especially for testing the mediation effect in H5.

3.4 Data Analysis

PLS-SEM will be used to test the proposed parallel mediation model. The model includes four reflective latent constructs: AI self-efficacy, trust in AI, perceived job threat and behavioral intention to adopt AI technologies. This method is suitable because the study examines latent constructs as well as the relationships between them within one model.

The central constructs cannot be observed directly. They are measured through several questionnaire items. PLS-SEM therefore allows the measurement model to be assessed before the direct and indirect effects are interpreted. Compared with regression based on aggregated scale scores, it provides a more detailed assessment of reliability and validity. PLS-SEM is also suitable for prediction-oriented research, medium-sized samples and data without strict normal distribution requirements (Hair et al., 2019, pp. 2–4). The empirical analysis will be conducted using SmartPLS.

The analysis will be carried out in two steps. First, the measurement model will be checked using common quality criteria, including reliability, validity and discriminant validity. After that, the structural model will be analyzed by looking at the relationships between the constructs, the explained variance and the predictive quality of the model.

For H5, the indirect effects will be tested with bootstrapping based on 5,000 samples. This will show whether trust and perceived job threat explain the relationship between AI self-efficacy and behavioral intention. If the indirect effects are significant, mediation is supported. If the direct effect of AI self-efficacy on behavioral intention remains significant, this indicates partial mediation. If the direct effect is no longer significant, full mediation is supported. The results will be discussed in relation to Montag et al. (2023, p. 1) and Kim and Kim (2024, p. 1). Collinearity will be checked using variance inflation factors (VIF).

3.5 Quality Criteria and Ethical Considerations

Since the study is based on self-reported survey data, common method bias may occur. This means that relationships between variables may be influenced by the fact that all answers come from the same respondents, rather than only by the actual theoretical relationships (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee & Podsakoff, 2003, pp. 879–880).

Several steps will be taken to reduce this risk. Respondents will be assured of anonymity, and all items will be formulated neutrally. In addition, predictor and outcome variables will be placed in separate sections of the questionnaire. Statistical checks, such as collinearity diagnostics and, if necessary, Harman’s single-factor test, will also be used.

The study uses a cross-sectional design, meaning that all data will be collected at one point in time. Therefore, the results will show relationships between variables, but they cannot prove causality. A longitudinal study could provide stronger evidence and may be useful for future research.

Participation in the survey is voluntary. Before starting, respondents will be informed about the purpose of the study, the anonymous handling of their data and the scientific use of the results.

4 Thesis Structure

This section presents the preliminary structure of the master's thesis, including the planned chapters, subchapters, and the main content to be addressed in each part. Furthermore, an estimated page count is provided for each chapter to ensure that the overall scope of the thesis corresponds to the required academic framework. An overview of the proposed thesis structure is provided in Table 1.

Chapter / Subchapter	Objective / Purpose	Est. Pages
1 Introduction	**Introduces the research topic, the problem statement, the research gap, and the research questions.**	**6**
1.1 Initial Situation and Problem Statement	Describes the organizational context of AI adoption in Austria and introduces the central psychological tension the study addresses.	2
1.2 Research Gap	Identifies the unexplored antecedent role of AI self-efficacy as the theoretical gap motivating the study.	2
1.3 Objectives and Research Questions	Presents the study's objectives, the main research question, sub-questions, and hypotheses.	2
2 Theoretical Background	**Provides the theoretical foundations for the conceptual model across six thematic areas.**	**32**
2.1 Artificial Intelligence in Organizations	Defines AI in organizational contexts and describes its relevance for work processes and decision-making.	4
2.2 Technology Acceptance Research	Presents TAM and UTAUT as foundational frameworks for explaining technology adoption behavior.	5
2.3 AI Acceptance and the Limits of Classical Models	Explains why AI opacity, autonomy, and employment implications require extensions to classical acceptance models.	4
2.4 Trust in AI	Discusses trust in AI as a central enabling factor, its dimensions, antecedents, and role in acceptance.	6
2.5 Perceived Job Threat and AI-Induced Job Insecurity	Examines AI-induced job insecurity, skill obsolescence, and their effects on employee attitudes and behavior.	6
2.6 AI Self-Efficacy	Develops the conceptual foundation for AI self-efficacy, drawing on social cognitive theory and AI-specific empirical evidence.	5
2.7 The Austrian Organizational Context	Contextualizes the study within Austria's AI adoption landscape, digital skills gap, and workforce policy environment.	2
3 Conceptual Model and Hypotheses	**Develops the parallel mediation model and derives all five hypotheses from the theoretical framework.**	**12**
3.1 Development of the Research Model	Integrates AI self-efficacy, trust in AI, and perceived job threat into a theoretically grounded parallel mediation framework.	2
3.2 H1: AI Self-Efficacy and Trust in AI	Derives the positive effect of self-efficacy on trust in AI based on social cognitive theory and empirical evidence.	2
3.3 H2: AI Self-Efficacy and Perceived Job Threat	Derives the negative effect of self-efficacy on perceived job threat and its theoretical grounding.	2
3.4 H3 and H4: Trust and Job Threat as Predictors of Behavioral Intention	Derives the direct effects of both mediators on adoption intention.	3
3.5 H5: Parallel Mediation	Derives the mediation hypotheses and presents the final visual research model.	2

Chapter / Subchapter	Objective / Purpose	Est. Pages
3.6 Summary of Hypotheses	Summarizes all hypotheses in a single overview table.	1
4 Methodology	**Explains and justifies the empirical research design.**	**14**
4.1 Research Design and Data Collection	Justifies the quantitative research approach, primary data collection, and online survey format.	2
4.2 Construct Operationalization	Presents measurement scales, adapted items, and example items for all four constructs.	4
4.3 Sampling Strategy and Survey Procedure	Explains the sampling approach, inclusion criteria, translation procedure, and pre-test.	3
4.4 Data Analysis	Describes the planned PLS-SEM analysis, measurement and structural model assessment, and mediation testing via bootstrapping.	3
4.5 Quality Criteria and Ethical Considerations	Discusses common method bias, cross-sectional design limitations, anonymity, and data protection.	2
5 Empirical Results	**Presents the survey data and PLS-SEM findings systematically.**	**16**
5.1 Data Screening and Sample Description	Describes data cleaning and sample characteristics.	3
5.2 Descriptive Statistics and Control Variables	Reports descriptive statistics, correlations, and control variable analysis.	2
5.3 Common Method Bias Assessment	Presents statistical checks for common method bias.	1
5.4 Measurement Model Assessment	Evaluates indicator reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity.	4
5.5 Structural Model and Mediation Analysis	Presents path coefficients, R^2, f^2, and bootstrapped indirect effects for the parallel mediation model.	6
6 Discussion	**Interprets the findings and derives theoretical and practical implications.**	**16**
6.1 Interpretation of Key Findings	Interprets results in relation to the research question and hypotheses.	3
6.2 Confrontation with Existing Literature	Positions findings in relation to Montag et al. (2023), Kim and Kim (2024), Duong et al. (2025), and related work.	3
6.3 Theoretical Contributions	Discusses contributions to AI adoption research, self-efficacy theory, and technology acceptance literature.	3
6.4 Practical Implications for Austrian Organizations	Derives evidence-based recommendations for organizations and professionals navigating AI adoption.	3
6.5 Limitations	Addresses methodological, contextual, and theoretical limitations of the study.	2
6.6 Future Research	Suggests directions for future empirical and theoretical work.	2
7 Conclusion	**Summarizes the thesis and answers the main research question.**	**4**
7.1 Summary	Summarizes objective, theoretical framework, methodology, and key findings.	1.5
7.2 Answer to the Research Question	Provides the final direct answer to the main research question.	1.5
7.3 Concluding Remarks	Closes with final reflections on the significance of the findings for organizations and future research.	1
References	Lists all cited sources	variable

Chapter / Subchapter	Objective / Purpose	Est. Pages
Appendices	Includes the questionnaire, measurement items and sources, SmartPLS output tables, and participant information sheet.	variable

Table 1: Thesis Structure

5 Time Management

This section outlines the preliminary timetable for the master's thesis by presenting the relevant dates, timeframes, key milestones, and planned activities throughout the thesis process. It covers the period from the submission of the research proposal to the final submission of the master's thesis. The timetable serves as a planning and progress-tracking tool, ensuring that the literature review, methodological preparation, data collection, data analysis, writing process, and final revision are completed within the required timeframe. An overview of the proposed timeline is provided in Table 2.

Date / Timeframe	Milestone / Activity	Description
28.05.2026	Submission of Research Proposal	Submission of the master's thesis research proposal via Moodle.
28.05.–17.06.2026	Preparation of Proposal Presentation	Preparation of the defensio presentation based on the submitted proposal and any supervisor feedback received prior to the defense.
18.–20.06.2026	Defensio of Research Proposal	Oral defense of the research proposal in front of the examination senate and peer group.
21.06.–31.07.2026	Literature Review and Theoretical Framework I	In-depth review of relevant literature and drafting of Chapters 1 and 2.1 through 2.4.
01.08.–31.08.2026	Literature Review and Theoretical Framework II	Drafting of Chapters 2.5 through 2.7 and preparation of the theoretical basis for Chapter 3.
01.09.–20.09.2026	Conceptual Model and Hypotheses	Development of the research model and derivation of all five hypotheses in Chapter 3.
21.09.–20.10.2026	Methodology	Drafting of Chapter 4, including research design, construct operationalization, sampling strategy, and data analysis plan.
06.09.2026	Feedback Meeting with Supervisor	Submission of draft Chapters 1 and 2 to the supervisor for early feedback.
21.10.–04.11.2026	Finalization of Theory Submission Draft	Revision, formatting, bibliography check, and proofreading of the theoretical part.
05.11.2026	Submission of Master's Thesis Theory	Submission of the theoretical part of the master's thesis via Moodle.
06.11.–20.11.2026	Survey Instrument Finalization	Final development of the online questionnaire and setup of the survey platform.
21.11.–27.11.2026	Pre-Test of Survey Instrument	Pre-test with five to ten participants and revision of unclear items.
28.11.–23.12.2026	Online Survey Data Collection	Distribution of the online survey among employees in Austrian organizations. Target: 150 to 200 valid responses.
04.01.–15.01.2027	Data Screening and Sample Description	Data cleaning, handling incomplete responses, and drafting of the sample description
16.01.–14.02.2027	Quantitative Data Analysis	PLS-SEM analysis in SmartPLS, including measurement model, structural model, mediation testing, and hypothesis testing.

Date / Timeframe	Milestone / Activity	Description
15.02.–28.02.2027	Writing of Empirical Results and Discussion	Drafting of Chapter 5 and Chapter 6, including interpretation of findings, theoretical contributions, practical implications, limitations, and future research.
01.03.–07.03.2027	Compilation of Appendices	Preparation of questionnaire, measurement items and sources, additional statistical results, and participant information.
08.03.2027	Feedback Meeting with Supervisor	Submission of the complete thesis draft to the supervisor for final feedback.
09.03.–22.03.2027	Final Revision	Incorporation of feedback, final proofreading, formal check, citation check, AI use documentation, and consistency check of tables and figures.
23.03.–24.03.2027	Final Formatting and Submission Preparation	Finalization of table of contents, abstract, lists, cover page, declaration of academic integrity, and upload preparation.
25.03.2027	Final Submission of Master's Thesis	Submission of the completed master's thesis via Moodle.
June 2027	Final Defensio of Master’s Thesis	Defense of the completed thesis.

Table 2: Time Schedule

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List of tools used

AI tool	Purpose	Concerned parts of the work	Notes
ChatGPT https://chatgpt.com	Translation of text passages and adaptations to scientific language style.	Whole document	
ClaudeAI https://claude.ai	Claude was used to support idea development and the structural organization of the thesis.	Initial research and conceptual development	
Deepl Translator https://www.deepl.com/de/translator	Translation of text passages.	Whole document	
Notebooklm https://notebooklm.google.com/	Support for the structural organization of the thesis (outline and key arguments) as well as summarizing and categorizing academic sources.	Initial research and structure of document	
Scribbr https://www.scribbr.at	Verification of citation and correctness	Whole document	